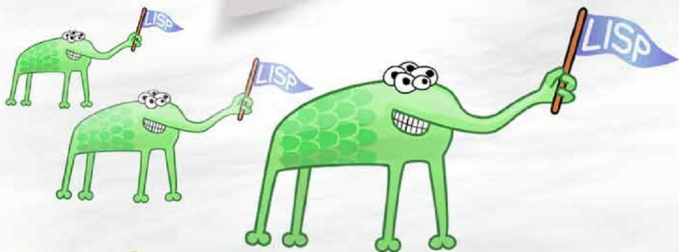


THE WORLD'S
MOST POWERFUL
PROGRAMMING
LANGUAGE



LISP

Tears of Joy

Part—2

Lisp has been hailed as the world's most powerful programming language. But only the top percentile of programmers use it, because of its cryptic syntax and academic reputation. This is rather unfortunate, since Lisp isn't that hard to grasp. If you want to be among the *crème de la crème*, this series is for you. This is the second article in the series that began in the June 2011 issue of LfY.

“I think that it's extraordinarily important that we in computer science keep the fun in computing. When it started out, it was an awful lot of fun. Of course, the paying customers got shafted every now and then, and after a while, we began to take their complaints seriously. We began to feel as if we really were responsible for the successful, error-free perfect use of these machines. I don't think we are. I think we're responsible for stretching them, setting them off in new directions, and keeping fun in the house. I hope the field of computer science never loses its sense of fun. Above all, I hope we don't become

missionaries. Don't feel as if you're a Bible salesman. The world has too many of those already. What you know about computing, other people will learn. Don't feel as if the key to successful computing is only in your hands. What's in your hands, I think and hope, is intelligence: the ability to see the machine as more than when you were first led up to it, that you can make it more.”

— Alan J Perlis (The first recipient of the Turing Award)

That quote by Perlis would resonate with those who read my previous scholarly article on Lisp, which, after all, is about having fun and stretching the capabilities of